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REFLECTIONS

A story of **authenticity**, **adaptation**,
and the **balance** between
two worlds.

Source *Karina Chow (UX Collective)*

v1.0
December 2025

• IMPORTANT •

A Note on this Project

This document was developed as part of a design challenge for a game studio, published here with their express permission.

All conceptual work and layout are of my own authorship, with the exception of decorative illustrations, whose sources are typically credited at the bottom of each page.

The background artwork used throughout this document is sourced from absurd.design.

Created in December 2025.

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INTRODUCTION

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

I have developed this document not only to showcase my Level Design competencies but also to provide insight into my creative process and natural workflow.

While this is not a formal Level Design Document (LDD), I have structured several sections similarly to better address the specific exercises presented in the challenge.

OBJECTIVE

Adhering to the criteria and constraints specified in the brief, my objective is to propose a puzzle/platformer level featuring two characters—each with distinct gameplay mechanics—across three unique environments.

As an additional challenge, I have integrated a cohesive narrative[1] layer that informs both the visual expression and the playability of the level. This decision is not merely aesthetic; it stems from my study of Nomada Studio's GRIS and Neva (both being my main references). Their level design reinforces a narrative that is never explicit, but consistently suggested through gameplay.

With this project, I sought to test my ability to conceive a design that achieves a similar synergy between mechanics and storytelling.

[1] Since narrative was not the primary focus of this technical test, it has been further developed as supplementary material in the "Design Memoir" section at the end of this document.

METHODOLOGY

PROJECT APPROACH

To meet the objectives of this challenge, I have structured this document into distinct sections, prioritized by their technical relevance.

I begin by addressing the **three core exercises:** character movesets and metrics, level mechanic design, and level layout. The language used in these opening sections is **technical** and **direct**, reflecting the standard documentation style of a formal **Level Design Document** (LDD).

The final section, titled **"Design Memoir"**, offers a more personal insight into my **creative process** and **ideation**. Its purpose is to provide context and rationale for the design decisions made throughout the technical exercises.

EXERCISE 1

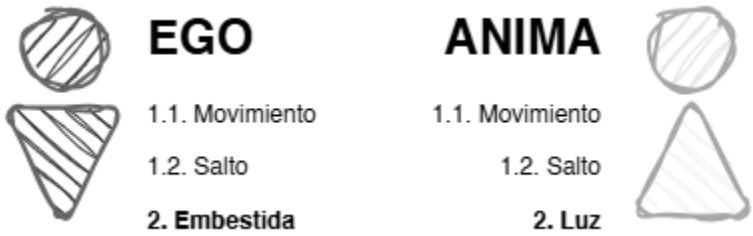
CHARACTER MOVESETS & METRICS

GENERAL OVERVIEW

To complete the "Reflections" level, the player must alternate between two distinct characters: **Ego** and **Anima**. While both share the **same core movement** and jumping mechanics, they are distinguished by a **unique secondary ability**.

This signature ability defines each character's playstyle and dictates how they interact with the level design challenges ahead.

***Source** Original work*



Ego, representing the **physical**, the **external**, and the **logical**, possesses a short lateral dash. Formally titled **"Dash"** (or Ram/Shoulder Bash), this mechanic not only enhances mobility but also **allows direct interaction with physical elements** in the environment, such as Reflecting Mirrors[2].

In contrast, **Anima**—representing the **psychic**, the **internal**, and the **abstract**—can transform into a **Sphere of Light**. This form allows her to **illuminate dark environments** and **merge with light beams** to traverse them. However, while in this transformed state, Anima **loses the ability to jump**.

[2] **Reflecting Mirrors**, detailed further in Exercise 2: Level Mechanic Design, are used to redirect light beams for puzzle-solving throughout the level.

OVERVIEW AND ASSUMPTIONS

The challenge brief explicitly states that the **two characters are never controlled simultaneously**; the player maintains control over only one avatar at any given time.

Switching is performed via a **dedicated controller or keyboard input**, with **each character maintaining their specific position** within the environment.

Since this mechanic was not the primary focus of the test, it is not developed in depth. However, several **critical design questions** cannot be ignored:

- Is the switching mechanic available from the start?
- Are both characters present on-screen at the same time?
- Does the inactive character follow the active one?

In the absence of these specifications, I have exercised **design autonomy** to define the following **parameters** for "Reflections":

- **Availability:** The character switching mechanic **is not available from the beginning**[3]. The player **unlocks** this ability after completing the first two stages.
- **Presence:** Both characters are **only present simultaneously** in the **third stage**, where cooperation is required to reach the final objective.
- **Follower AI & Pacing:** To maintain **optimal pacing**, the inactive character follows the active one during predetermined navigation sequences. However, this behavior ceases upon entering puzzle areas, where the player must manually toggle control between avatars to progress.

[3] An alternative method for switching characters is described in Exercise 3: Level Design.

ADDITIONAL CONSIDERATIONS

This exercise (Character Movesets & Metrics) is structured into two main sections:

EGO'S MECHANICS:

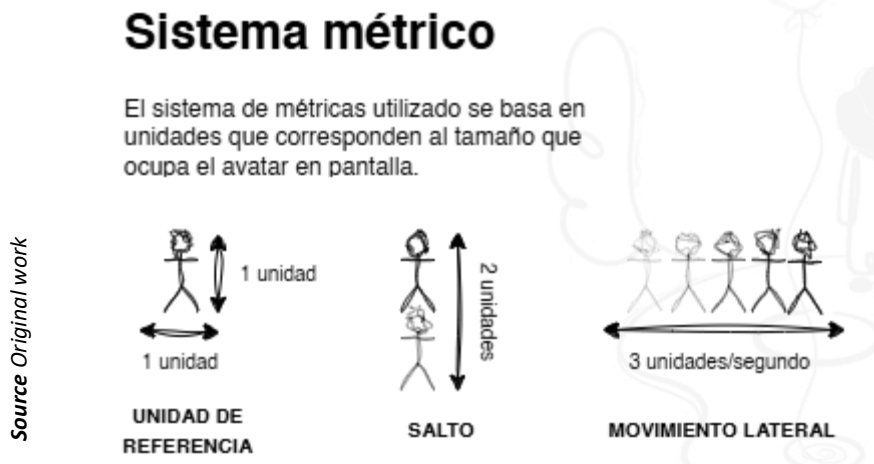
- **1.1. Movement:** Describes the character's lateral movement.
- **1.2. Jump:** Defines jump mechanics and character metrics.
- **2. Dash:** Detailed breakdown of Ego's unique signature mechanic.

ANIMA'S MECHANICS:

- **1.1. Movement:** Describes the character's lateral movement.
- **1.2. Jump:** Defines jump mechanics and character metrics.
- **2. Light:** Detailed breakdown of Anima's unique signature mechanic.

Sections **1.1 (Movement)** and **1.2 (Jump)** are **identical for both characters**. I have deliberately chosen to maintain this redundant structure—rather than creating a separate general section—to allow the reader to quickly reference a character's full moveset without cross-referencing other pages. This organization also streamlines future iterations, such as implementing specific variations in movement or jump physics for each character.

Finally, the **metrics** have been defined using a streamlined system based on the **avatar's scale**, as illustrated in the following diagram:



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EGO'S MECHANICS

*Ego represents the physical, the external, and the logical. His signature ability, **Dash**, provides extra dynamism and mobility while enabling him to solve logic-based puzzles.*

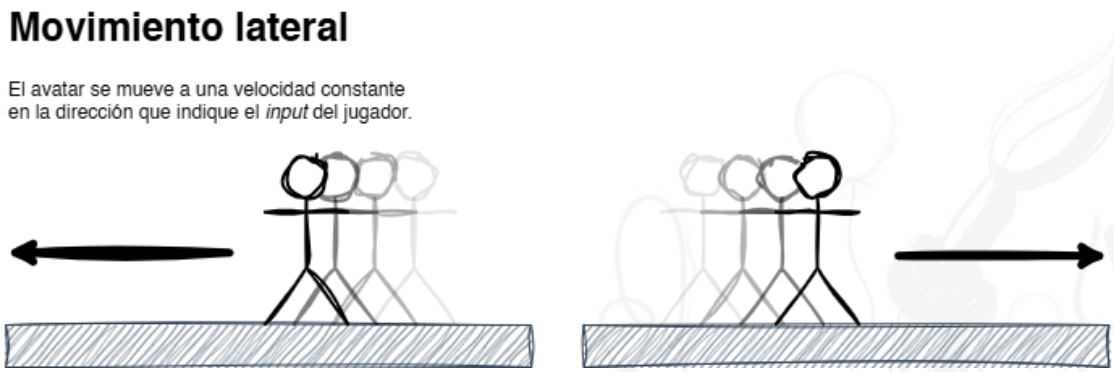
***Source** Klaufir*

1.1. Movement

***Important Note:** This mechanic is identical for both Ego and Anima. It is included here redundantly to allow the reader to quickly grasp each character's full range of actions without cross-referencing other sections.*

The core movement is directly inspired by GRIS (Nomada Studio, 2018), maintaining its established feel without additional modifications.

The player has direct control over the avatar via **keyboard** or **controller**. **Holding** the **movement key**[4] (or tilting the analog stick) to the **left** or **right** causes the avatar to **run** in that **direction**. Notably, if a controller is used and the stick is **only partially tilted**, the avatar will **walk** instead of run.



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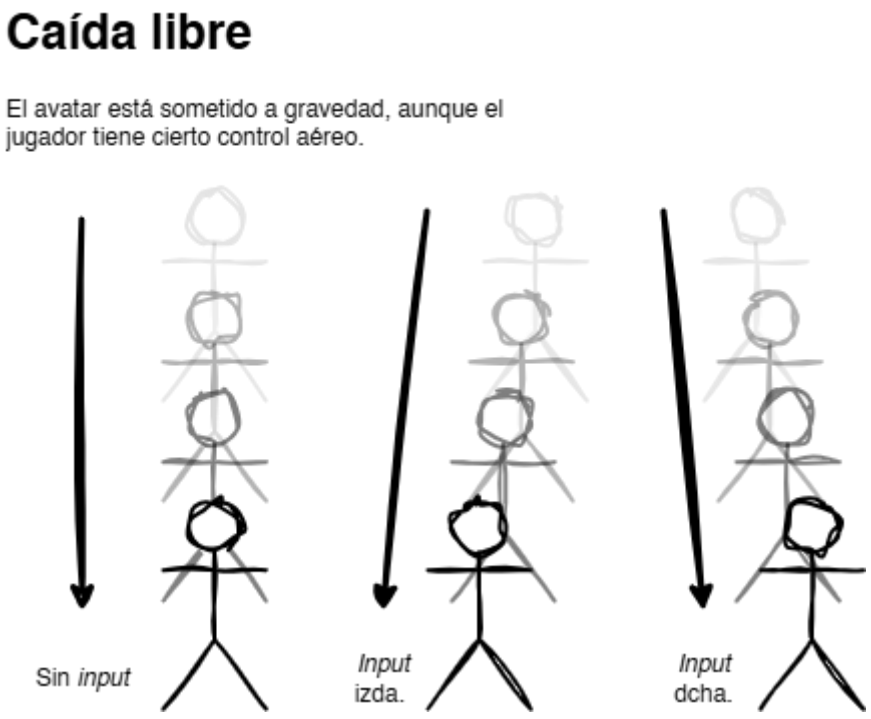
[4] Following the example of GRIS, the left movement input corresponds to the "A" key, while the right movement input corresponds to the "D" key.

Movement speed remains constant[5]. Upon releasing the movement key (or returning the analog stick to its neutral position), the avatar **stops immediately**. This provides the precise, snappy control required for the platforming sections.

The avatar is subject to **gravity**: during freefall, its downward velocity increases progressively due to constant acceleration until it reaches a predetermined terminal velocity (maximum fall speed).



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There is **no fall damage**, as the level design does not include scenarios where player death can occur.

While falling, the player retains **mid-air control** (lateral influence): movement inputs can still be used to shift the character left or right. However, this aerial movement is performed at a lower speed than ground movement.

[5] There is no acceleration or friction (deceleration) applied to horizontal movement. The avatar reaches its maximum speed instantly and comes to a complete halt the moment the input is released.

In summary, the **movement** is determined by these rules:

- **Standard Locomotion:** The avatar runs left or right as long as the player holds the corresponding input.
  - **Analog Input:** When using a controller, partially tilting the analog stick causes the avatar to walk instead of run.
  - **Velocity:** Lateral movement speed is constant, at approximately 3–4 Units per Second (UPS)[6], where 1 unit is equivalent to the avatar's visual height on screen.
  - **Acceleration/Friction:** There is no acceleration or deceleration in horizontal movement; the avatar reaches maximum speed and stops instantaneously.
- **Gravity & Freefall:** The avatar is subject to gravity. When falling from a platform (or during the descent phase of a jump), downward velocity increases via constant acceleration until it reaches a predetermined terminal velocity.
  - **Aerial Drift (Mid-air Control):** During freefall, the player retains limited lateral control. The avatar can be shifted left or right at a reduced speed of approximately 1–2 Units per Second, significantly lower than grounded movement.
  - **Fall Damage:** No fall damage is applied, as the level layout does not feature lethal falls.

[6] This metric is an initial estimate and must be validated during the prototyping and greyboxing phase to determine if further tuning is required.

1.2. Jump

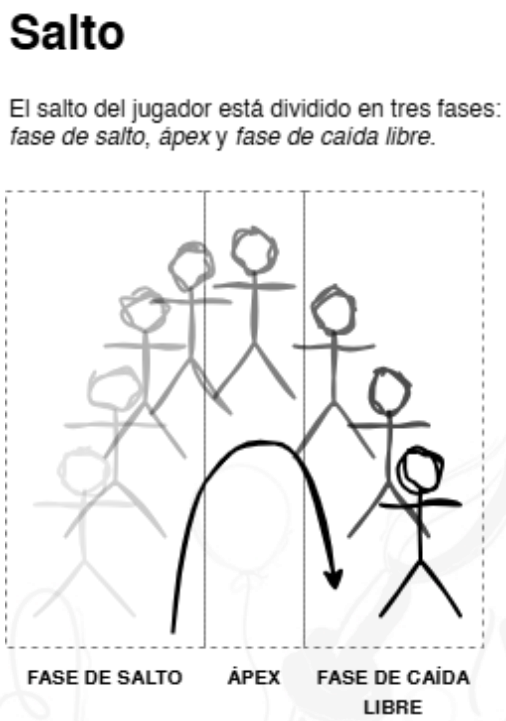
Important Note: *This mechanic is identical for both Ego and Anima. It is included here redundantly to ensure the reader can quickly grasp each character's full range of actions without cross-referencing other sections.*

Upon pressing the jump input, the avatar performs a jump that follows a parabolic trajectory. The player can modulate the **Jump Height** by holding the button: the longer the input is held, the higher the avatar reaches (**Variable Jump Height**).

The **Maximum Jump Height** is approximately **2–2.5 units**[7], while the **Minimum Jump Height** is **1.3–1.4 units** (where 1 unit equals the avatar's visual height on screen).

To better understand the mechanics, the jump is divided into **three sequential phases**:

- **Ascent Phase:** From the moment the jump input is registered until the avatar reaches its maximum vertical point.
- **Apex:** The specific moment at the top of the trajectory where vertical velocity is zero before the descent begins.
- **Descent (Freefall) Phase:** From the moment the avatar begins to fall due to gravity until it makes contact with the ground, concluding the jump.



Source *Original work*

[7] This metric is an initial estimate and must be validated during the prototyping phase to determine if adjustments are required for optimal gameplay feel.

The **Ascent Phase** lasts approximately **1 second**, though it can be interrupted prematurely if the player releases the jump button before the avatar reaches the apex.

In contrast, the duration of the **Descent Phase** is variable, depending on two factors: the vertical distance to the landing surface and the specific programming method used to implement the mechanic[8].

The player retains **lateral control** throughout all three phases of the jump, with varying degrees of influence:

- **Ascent and Apex:** While the avatar is powered by the upward jump force, **normal lateral mobility** is maintained (3–4 Units per Second, as defined in section "1.1. Movement").
- **Descent (Freefall):** Once the upward momentum is spent, the lateral speed is **reduced** (to 1–2 Units per Second, as defined in section "1.1. Movement") until the avatar grounds. This allows the player to perform precise jumps and better calculate the landing trajectory.

The jump is the **core mechanic** of Reflections, as most challenges require platforming to progress. To avoid player confusion, both Ego and Anima share identical jump metrics, ensuring a consistent and predictable feel regardless of the character being controlled.

•

Alternatively, a differentiation between the two avatars could be explored to reinforce their themes:

- ***Ego:*** *As the more "physical" character, he could be given more* ***weight*** *by adding a variable that increases his* ***falling acceleration*** *during the Descent Phase.*

[8] One implementation approach involves disabling gravity during the Ascent Phase: the altitude would increase linearly until the apex is reached. At that point, gravity would be re-enabled, allowing the avatar to follow the intended parabolic curve during the Descent Phase.

- ***Anima:*** *Being lighter, she could benefit from an* ***extended Ascent Phase*** *(e.g., 1.5 seconds instead of 1.0), giving her a loftier, more ethereal jump feel.*

In any case, these alternatives should be explored and validated in a prototype to ensure the game feel remains cohesive and does not lead to confusing or frustrating player experiences.

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Por último, se resumen las métricas relevantes para definir el salto en la tabla que se dispone a continuación:

METRIC	DESCRIPTION	ESTIMATED VALUE
Avatar Scale	*The reference value describing the visual height of the avatar on screen.*	**1 Unit**
Max Jump Height	*The maximum vertical peak the avatar can reach during a jump.*	**2.0 – 2.5 Units**
Min Jump Height	*The minimum vertical peak reached when the jump input is released immediately.*	**1.3 – 1.4 Units**
Jump Duration	*The maximum time the avatar spends in the Ascent Phase before entering freefall.*	**1 Second**
Air Control (Freefall)[9]	*The lateral movement speed available to the player during the descent phase.*	**1 – 2 Units/Sec**

[9] Air Control is further detailed and developed in section "1.1. Movement."

2. Dash (Ram/Shoulder Bash)

The **"Dash"** is Ego's signature ability and fundamentally defines his gameplay, both in platforming challenges and logic-based puzzles.

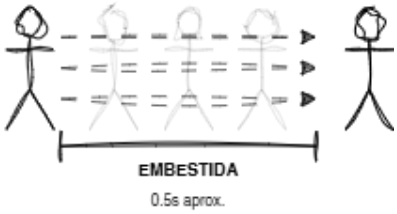
As the name suggests, triggering this ability causes the avatar to instantly traverse **3 units** in the facing direction (Left or Right).

***Source** Original work*

Embestida

El avatar de desplaza inmediatamente tres (3) unidades hacia la dirección en la que esté mirando.

La embestida también puede activar objetos interactivos que se encuentren en la trayectoria del movimiento.



While this horizontal displacement functions similarly to a standard dash, it is designed with greater **physical force** and visual impact.

If the avatar collides with interactive objects—such as fragile vases, buttons, or levers—the momentum of the dash triggers them.

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> *To reinforce the sense of power, the dash should be accompanied by a brief wind gust effect and a "heavy," dry sound effect. It is crucial that the mechanic conveys not just speed, but a sense of* ***weight and impact****.*

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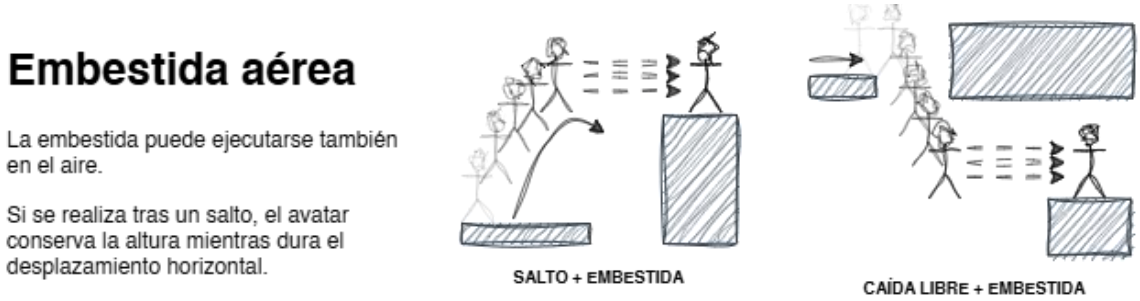
This ability can be used both on the ground and in mid-air, serving as an additional horizontal boost to reach platforms that would otherwise be inaccessible.

If performed mid-air, gravity and all downward forces are suspended for the duration of the dash. This ensures a clean horizontal trajectory until the mechanic concludes and gravity is restored.



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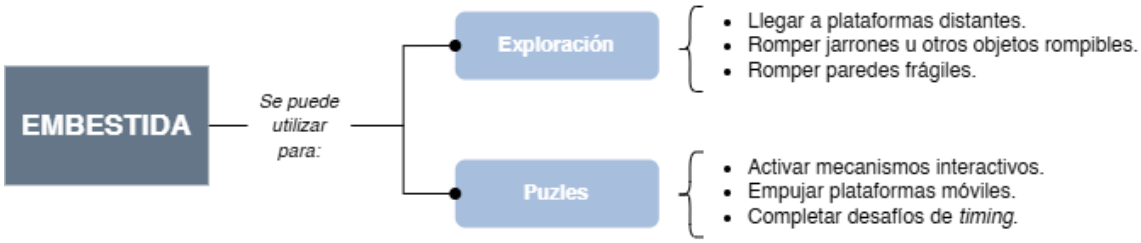
To prevent ability spamming, a **cooldown of approximately 1 second** is implemented between uses. Once this period has elapsed, the avatar can trigger the dash again.

The metrics relevant to defining the “Dash” are summarized in the table below:

METRIC	DESCRIPTION	ESTIMATED VALUE
Movement Speed	*The reference value for the avatar's horizontal travel speed.*	**3–4 Units/Sec**
Dash Distance	*The total distance covered by the avatar during the dash.*	**3 Units**
Ability Duration	*The time elapsed from the start to the end of the dash.*	**0.5 Seconds**
Cooldown	*The recovery time required before the ability can be used again.*	**1 Second**

Emergent Gameplay & Mechanics Potential

To illustrate the versatility of the **Dash**, the following section outlines potential gameplay dynamics. While some of these variations would require additional elements (such as new platform types or interactive mechanisms) beyond the scope of this specific challenge, they serve to justify the mechanic's inclusion by showcasing its long-term potential.



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Current and Future Applications

- **Traversal & Navigation:** In "Reflections", the Dash primarily functions as a mobility tool, allowing the avatar to reach platforms otherwise inaccessible via standard jumping.
- **Environmental Interaction:** The mechanic possesses sufficient physical force to **destroy fragile objects**, such as vases or cracked walls, potentially revealing secret paths or hidden areas.
- **Mechanism Activation:** The Dash can trigger interactive elements like levers, buttons, and the **Reflecting Mirrors** detailed in Exercise 2.
- **Hypothetical Dynamics:**
    - **Dynamic Obstacles:** In future iterations, the Dash could be used to push and **reposition mobile platforms**, adding a layer of spatial puzzle-solving.
    - **Timing Challenges:** The ability could be central to "race against time" scenarios, where the player must use the Dash's instantaneous burst of speed to pass through closing gates or reach objectives before a timer expires.

ANIMA'S MECHANICS

*Anima represents the psychic, the internal, and the abstract. Her signature ability, **Light**, allows her to navigate lightless environments and reveal hidden areas within the level.*

***Source** Inês Merino*

1.2. Movement

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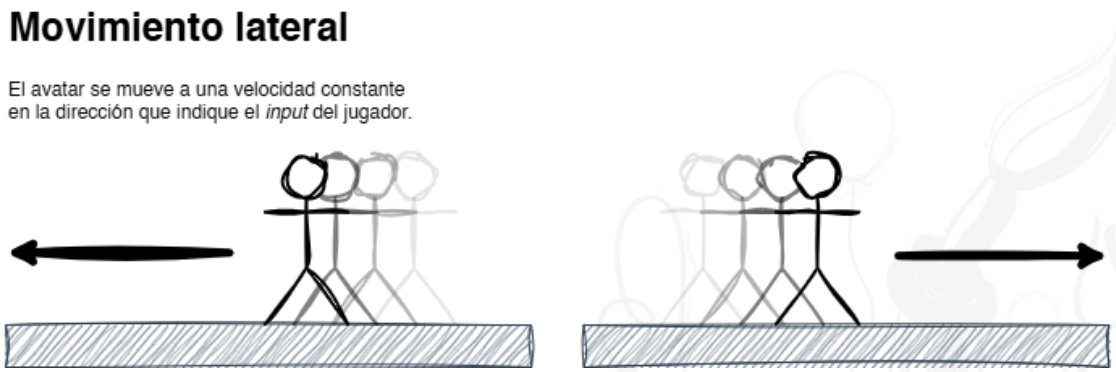

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Movement speed remains constant[11]. Upon releasing the movement key (or returning the analog stick to its neutral position), the avatar **stops immediately**. This provides the precise, snappy control required for the platforming sections.

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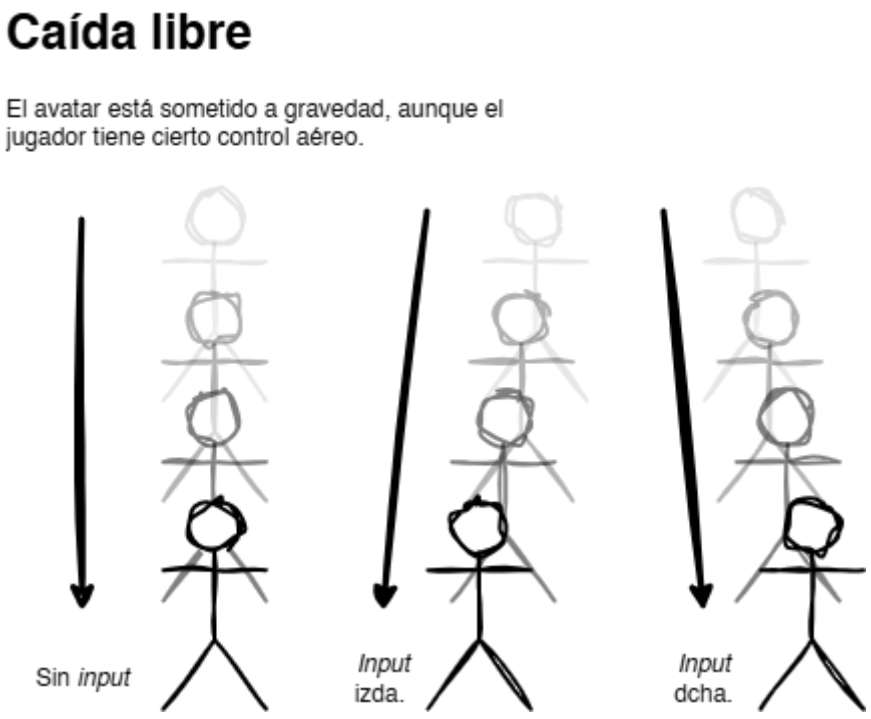

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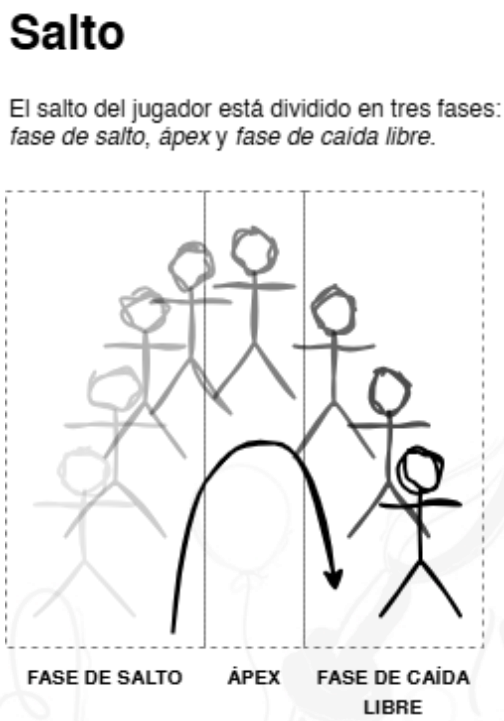

Source *Original work*

[13] This metric is an initial estimate and must be validated during the prototyping phase to determine if adjustments are required for optimal gameplay feel.

The **Ascent Phase** lasts approximately **1 second**, though it can be interrupted prematurely if the player releases the jump button before the avatar reaches the apex.

In contrast, the duration of the **Descent Phase** is variable, depending on two factors: the vertical distance to the landing surface and the specific programming method used to implement the mechanic[14].

The player retains **lateral control** throughout all three phases of the jump, with varying degrees of influence:

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- ***Anima:*** *Being lighter, she could benefit from an* ***extended Ascent Phase*** *(e.g., 1.5 seconds instead of 1.0), giving her a loftier, more ethereal jump feel.*

In any case, these alternatives should be explored and validated in a prototype to ensure the game feel remains cohesive and does not lead to confusing or frustrating player experiences.

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Por último, se resumen las métricas relevantes para definir el salto en la tabla que se dispone a continuación:

METRIC	DESCRIPTION	ESTIMATED VALUE
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Max Jump Height	*The maximum vertical peak the avatar can reach during a jump.*	**2.0 – 2.5 Units**
Min Jump Height	*The minimum vertical peak reached when the jump input is released immediately.*	**1.3 – 1.4 Units**
Jump Duration	*The maximum time the avatar spends in the Ascent Phase before entering freefall.*	**1 Second**
Air Control (Freefall)[15]	*The lateral movement speed available to the player during the descent phase.*	**1 – 2 Units/Sec**

[15] Air Control is further detailed and developed in section "1.1. Movement."

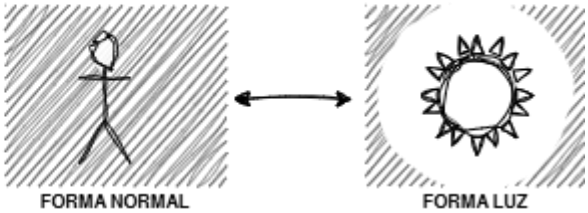
2. Light

The "**Light"** ability is Anima's signature mechanic. It shifts the gameplay focus toward exploration and environmental interaction within the level.

Luz

El avatar se transforma en una esfera de luz que ilumina el espacio inmediato.

Sin embargo, pierde a cambio la capacidad de saltar.



Source *Original work*

Upon pressing and holding the "Light" input, the avatar transforms into a luminous sphere, illuminating its immediate surroundings within a **10-unit radius** in all directions. Throughout this section, this state will be referred to as **"Light Form"**.

While in **Light Form**, Anima remains subject to gravity and maintains her standard movement metrics (3–4 Units/Sec). However, she incurs an **ability trade-off**: she loses the capacity to jump.

The Light Form remains active as long as the player holds the designated input and concludes immediately upon release, at which point the avatar reverts to her original form.

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To support players with physical disabilities or to improve ergonomics, the "hold-to-activate" input could be replaced with a toggle system (press once to transform, press again to revert).

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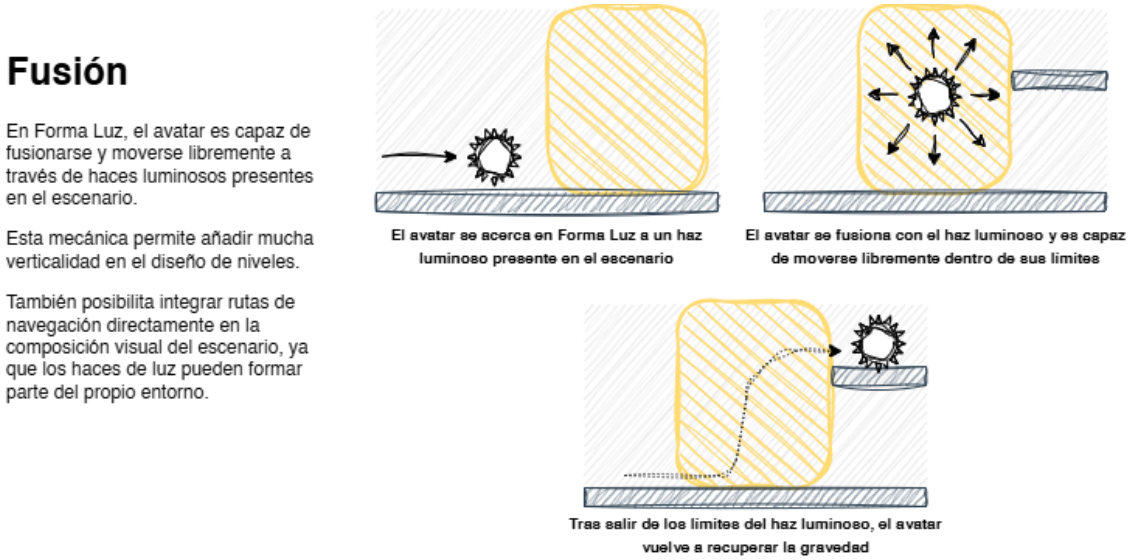
A key property of the Light Form is that it allows the avatar to **merge with light beams**, using them as pathways for traversal.

This fusion is triggered automatically when the avatar, while in **Light Form**, makes contact with a light beam—no additional input is required. Upon interaction, gravity is **nullified**, granting the avatar full **8-way directional movement** (horizontal, vertical, and diagonal) within the boundaries of the beam.



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This freedom of movement is similar to the swimming mechanic in **GRIS** (Nomada Studio, 2018), where the character fluidly ascends waterfalls.

Leaving the visual boundaries of the light beam ends the fusion and immediately restores gravity.

In **summary**, **"Light"** gives the avatar the following capabilities:

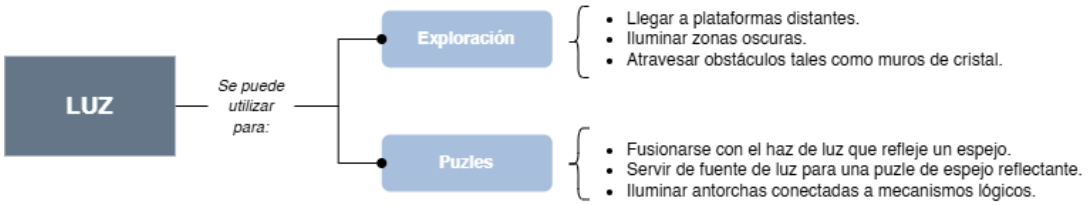
- **Transformation:** Anima becomes a luminous sphere (Light Form).
- **Illumination:** In this state, Anima reveals environmental elements in the dark within a **10-unit radius**.
- **Traversal:** Allows the avatar to merge with and move freely through environmental light beams.
- **Constraints:** While in Light Form, Anima **cannot jump**.

Next, the relevant metrics for defining “Light” are defined in the table below:

METRIC	DESCRIPTION	ESTIMATED VALUE
Avatar Scale	*Reference value for the avatar’s visual height on screen.*	**1 Unit**
Light Radius	*The illumination range emitted by the avatar in Light Form.*	**10 Units**
Transformation Time	*The duration of the transition into and out of Light Form upon input.*	**0.5 Seconds**

Emergent Gameplay & Mechanics Potential

Based on the integrated mechanics, the **Light Form** offers a wide range of possibilities for both exploration and puzzle-solving:



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- **Exploration:**
  - **Advanced Traversal:** Use light beams as "highways" to reach distant platforms or bypass traditional platforming sections by merging with the light.
  - **Environmental Visibility:** Reveal hidden paths, collectible items, or hazards in unlit areas of the level.
  - **Phasing Mechanics:** Pass through specific physical obstacles, such as glass walls, which are solid to Ego but permeable to Anima in her Light Form.

- **Puzzle Solving:**
  - **Reflective Interaction:** Merge with light beams reflected by mirrors to change elevation or cross large gaps.
  - **Mobile Light Source:** Act as a "living battery" or focal point to power photo-sensitive sensors or reflective mirror puzzles.
  - **Sequential Logic:** Activate environmental triggers, such as lighting torches, to unlock doors or toggle mechanical platforms.

EXERCISE 2

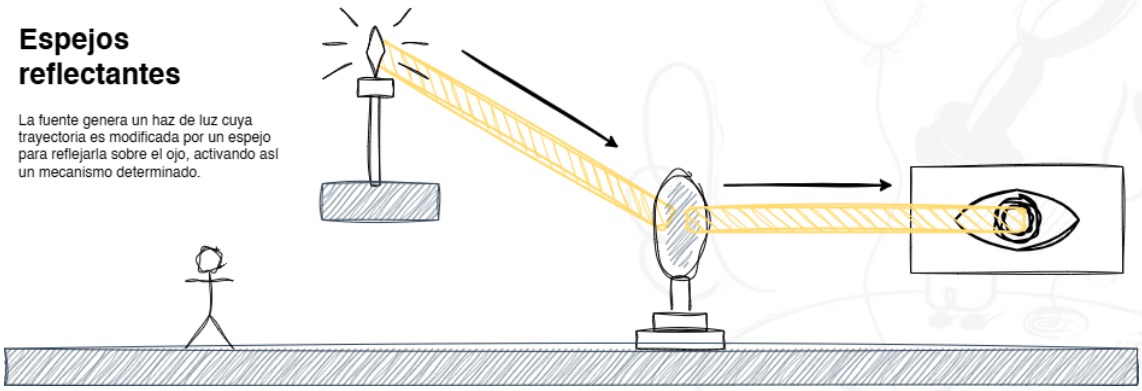
LEVEL MECHANIC DESIGN

GENERAL DESCRIPTION

The core level mechanic for *Reflections* is called **"Reflective Mirrors"**. These are logic-based mechanisms composed of three primary components: the **Source**, the **Mirrors**, and the **Eye**.

***Source** Original work*

- **The Source:** Emits an intense light beam that travels in a straight line. Its trajectory can be altered by reflecting off mirrors.
- **The Mirrors:** Reflective surfaces used to redirect the beam's path.
- **The Eye:** A stone structure that acts as a receiver. When the beam strikes the Eye directly, it triggers a specific event—typically opening a locked door or activating a secondary mechanism.



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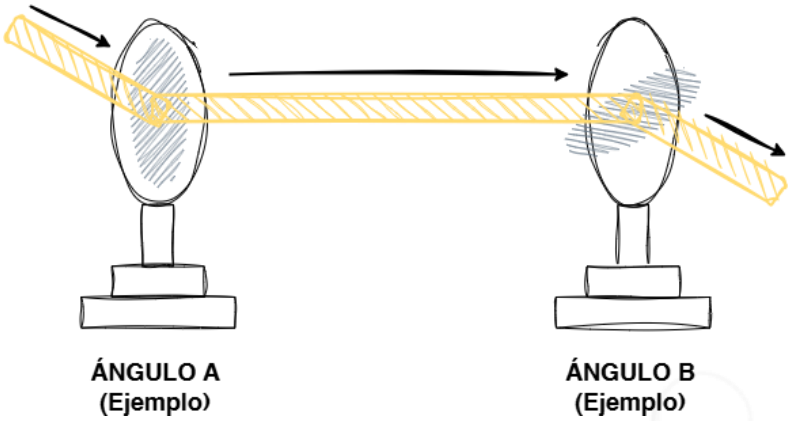
Mirrors are designed to redirect the light beam in any primary direction (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal). However, each individual mirror is restricted to **two specific orientations**—referred to as **Angle A** and **Angle B**—which determine the possible directions for the reflected beam.

These orientations are **context-specific** rather than universal:

- Each mirror has its own unique pair of angles based on the level design requirements.
- For instance, one mirror might toggle between reflecting **Left** and **Down**, while another might alternate between **Up** and **Right**.
- A single light beam can be reflected sequentially by multiple mirrors, each set to different angles, to create complex paths toward the objective.



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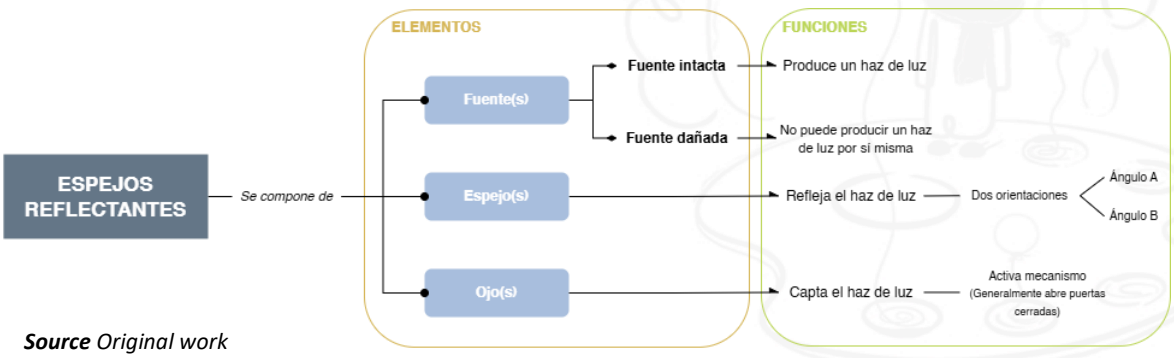
A key variation in the level design involves the **Damaged Source**. In certain scenarios, the primary light emitter may be inactive or broken, failing to generate a beam on its own. This state creates a systemic dependency: the player must provide an external light source (such as **Anima in Light Form**) to manually "jumpstart" or substitute the source to complete the circuit.

Finally, the mechanics can be **summarized** in the following descriptive points:

- **Core System:** The "Reflective Mirrors" act as the central logic puzzle for the Reflections level.
- **Anatomy of the Puzzle:** The system consists of three distinct actors: the **Source** (Emitter), the **Mirrors** (Redirectors), and the **Eye** (Receiver).
- **The Light Beam:** The Source emits a linear beam of light; its trajectory is altered upon contact with a mirror's reflective surface.
- **Win State:** When the beam successfully strikes the Eye, it triggers a gameplay event (typically unlocking a door or path).
- **Binary Mirror States:** Mirrors can redirect light in any direction (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal), but each unit is limited to **two specific orientations** (Angle A and Angle B).
    - These angles are not universal; each mirror is pre-set by the level designer to toggle between two specific directions (e.g., one toggles "Up/Right," another "Down/Left").
- **Chaining:** A single beam can be reflected sequentially by multiple mirrors to navigate complex environmental layouts.
- **Source Integrity:** The Source may be functional (active) or damaged (inactive), requiring the player to intervene as a manual light source.



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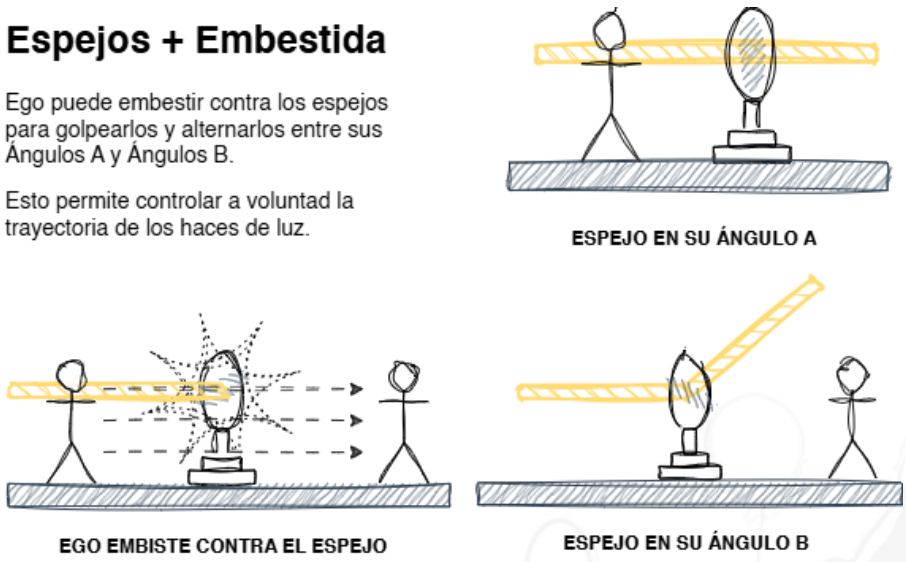
CHARACTER INTERACTIONS

As a logic-based system, this level mechanic always requires **direct player interaction** to function.

The "Reflective Mirrors" operate differently depending on which character is currently under the player's control, utilizing their unique abilities (**Ego's Dash** and **Anima's Light**) to provide distinct solutions.

1. Interaction with Ego

Ego—representing the physical and logical aspects of the duo—uses his **Dash ability**[16] to strike the mirrors. This physical impact toggles the mirror between **Angle A** and **Angle B**.



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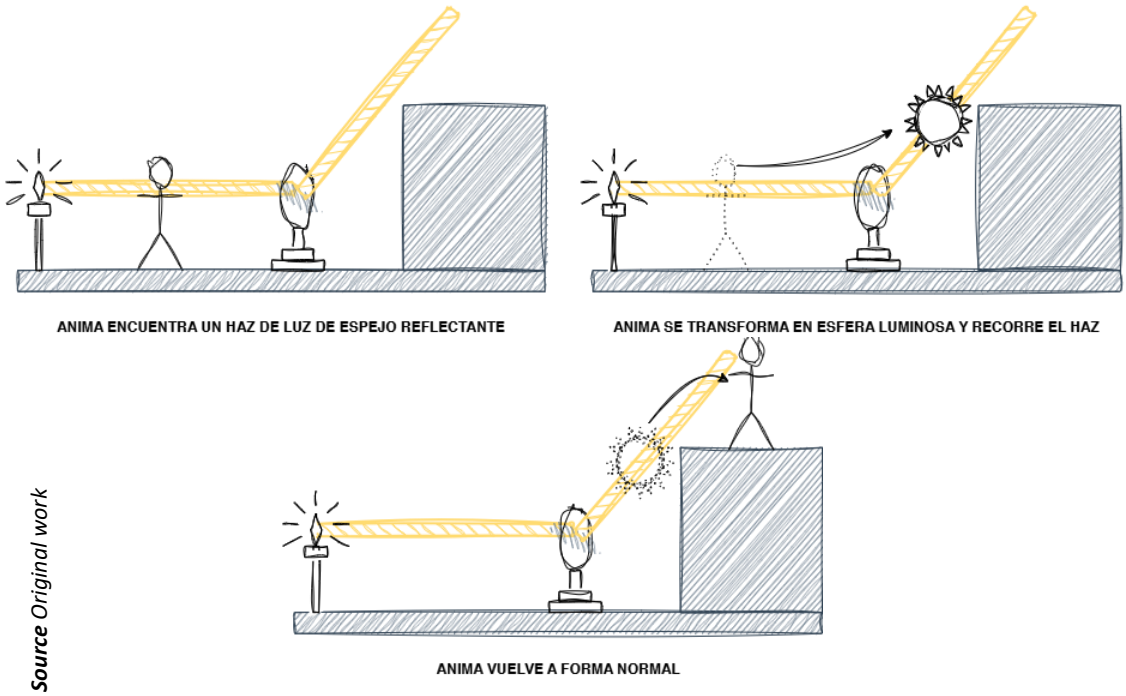
By doing so, Ego can manually reroute the trajectory of the light beams, making him the only character capable of **directly reconfiguring the puzzle layout**.

[16] Ego's Dash is detailed in "Exercise 1: Character Moveset & Metrics." It functions as a horizontal burst of speed with enough physical force to trigger interactive objects, such as breakable vases, levers, or in this case, rotating mirror housings.

2. Interaction with Anima

Anima—being the more abstract and ethereal character—cannot physically interact with the mirrors. However, by adopting her **Light Form**[17], she can **merge** with the light beams emitted by the sources.



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This property creates a compelling synergy between the two characters: Ego acts as the "architect," using his Dash to toggle mirror angles and configure the beam's trajectory, while Anima acts as the "navigator," utilizing those same light beams as pathways to reach areas that are physically inaccessible to Ego.

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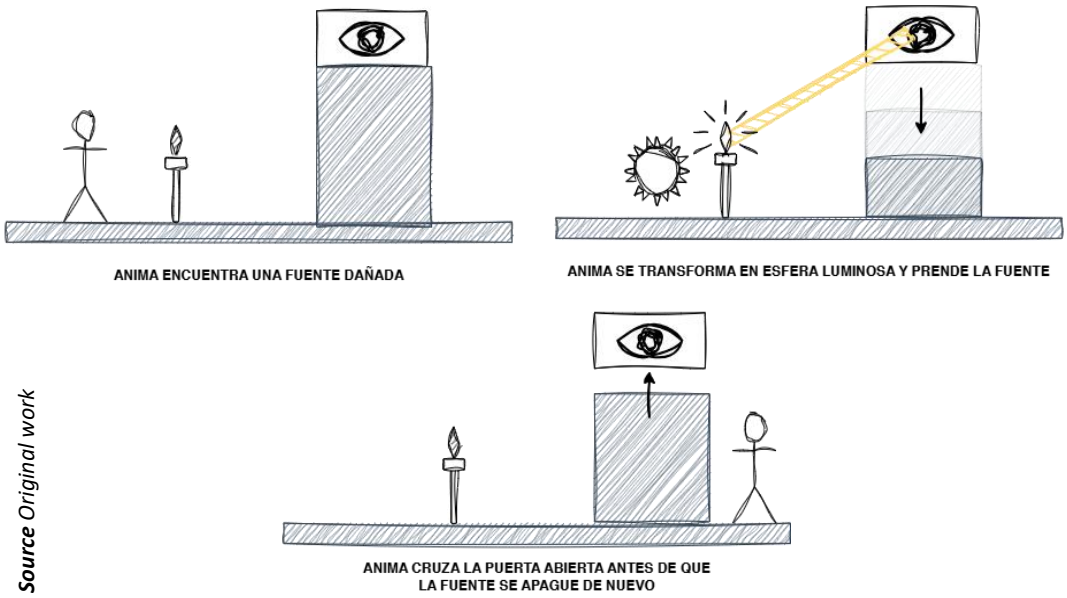
[17] Anima's Light Form is detailed in "Exercise 1: Character Moveset & Metrics." It allows her to transform into a luminous sphere, merging with and navigating freely within the visual boundaries of light beams present in the environment.

Furthermore, if Anima in Light Form makes contact with a **Damaged Source**, she acts as a temporary power supply, **reactivating it**. This triggers a light beam that gradually fades over time (**decaying light**). This mechanic allows for the design of **timing-based** challenges, where the player must navigate the resulting path or trigger the "Eye" before the source depletes.



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DESIGN RATIONALE

The inclusion of the Reflective Mirrors mechanic is justified by the following reasons:

- The relationship between Light + Mirrors is part of universal mental models. This allows the player to grasp the core logic almost immediately, minimizing the need for intrusive tutorials.
- The mechanic allows for a smooth difficulty curve. Complexity can be scaled simply by adjusting the quantity and placement of the three core elements (Sources, Mirrors, and Eyes) without needing to program new behaviors.

- Light acts as a natural "breadcrumb" or visual guide, directing the player's attention toward objectives and creating unexpected traversal routes through the environment.

- The mechanic can be expanded with the addition of:

  - **Mobile mirrors:** Reflectors mounted on tracks or platforms that the player must reposition.

  - **Timer-based mirrors:** Mirrors that automatically toggle between Angle A and B at set intervals.

  - **Multi-input receivers:** Eyes that require simultaneous illumination from multiple light beams to trigger a single event.

EXERCISE 3

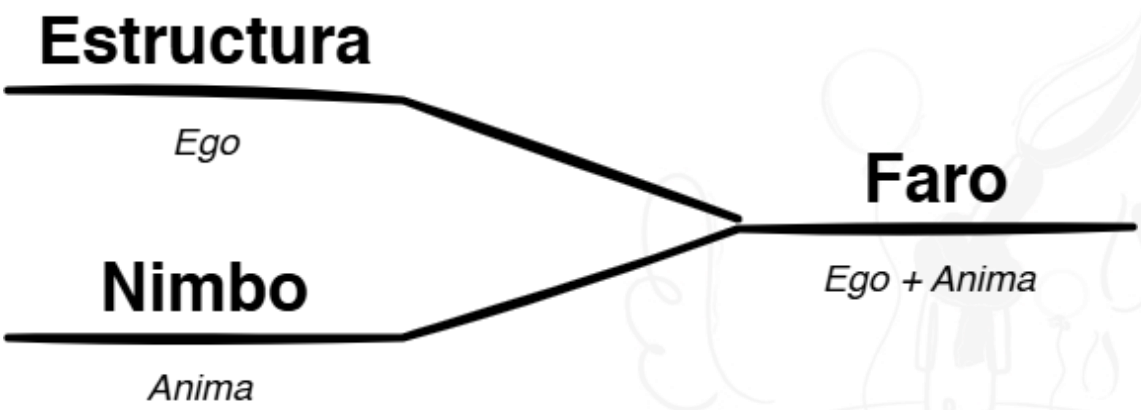
LEVEL DESIGN

GENERAL OVERVIEW

The level "Reflections" is divided into three distinct scenarios, each featuring unique logic puzzles and platforming challenges: **Estructura**, **Nimbo**, and **Faro**.

The player is given the agency to choose their starting point: **Estructura** (where the player exclusively controls Ego) or **Nimbo** (where the player exclusively controls Anima).

Upon completing both introductory scenarios, the final stage—**Faro**—is unlocked. In this climax, Ego and Anima must work in tandem. At this stage, the player unlocks the **Character Swap** mechanic (via a dedicated button), allowing them to navigate challenges with a significantly higher difficulty curve that requires the synergy of both movesets.



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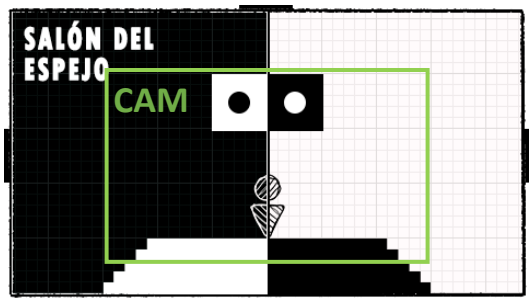
THE MIRROR HALL: DYNAMIC CHARACTER SELECTION

As previously noted, the manual **Character Swap** mechanic is not available from the start. Instead, the journey begins in a central hub known as the **Mirror Hall**. This space is bisected by a massive vertical mirror line, creating two symmetrical zones that reflect each other perfectly.

At the start, the player's avatar is positioned at the exact center of the mirror: visually, the body is split in two—one half representing **Ego** and the other **Anima**.



La partida comienza y el espejo divide a Ego y Anima (izda. y dcha. respectivamente).
La cámara está centrada en el medio.

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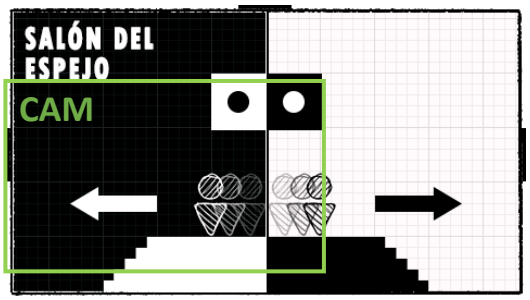


El jugador decide moverse hacia la izquierda, lo que provoca que:
A) Ego se vuelva el personaje activo
B) la cámara siga a Ego
C) Anima sea el reflejo e imite los movimientos de Ego hasta que salga fuera de cámara.

The player's initial movement dictates which character becomes the active avatar:

- **Movement to the Left:** The camera locks onto Ego, who detaches from the mirror line to become the active character. In the reflected zone, Anima acts as a "ghost" or "echo," mirroring Ego's movements until he exits the hall and enters the **Estructura** stage.

- **Movement to the Right:** The opposite occurs—Anima becomes the active avatar, and Ego becomes the reflection, leading into the **Nimbo** stage.

This system ensures player freedom. If a player feels stuck or wishes to switch challenges between **Estructura** and **Nimbo**, they can simply return to the **Mirror Hall** and cross the threshold in the opposite direction to swap characters.

Once **Estructura** and **Nimbo** are completed, the central mirror in the Mirror Hall shatters, revealing the path to **Faro**. This transition marks the physical reunion of Ego and Anima, granting the player the ability to **swap characters freely** to overcome the final stage.

The decision to use the Mirror Hall as the character-selection hub is based on the following three design pillars:

- **Mechanical Clarity:** Since “Reflections” is designed as a standalone, self-contained level, introducing the character-swap mechanic at the very beginning could lead to player confusion. By isolating Ego and Anima in their respective scenarios (Estructura and Nimbo), the player masters each moveset individually before the mechanic becomes essential in the third stage. This ensures a gradual and coherent learning curve.

- **Narrative Metaphor:** The Mirror Hall reinforces the level's central symbolism: Ego and Anima represent two opposing facets of the self—the logical/external and the abstract/internal. Presenting them as reflections divided by a mirror emphasizes this duality through gameplay.

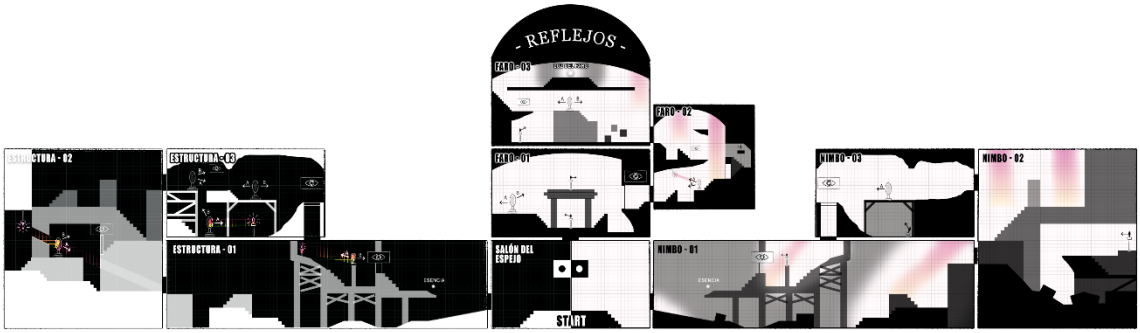
- **Clear Objectives and Memorable Beats:** The mirror acts as a clear goalpost. The shattering of the glass serves as a "High Point" or "Climax" in the level’s pacing: a visually impactful moment that justifies the level’s title, “Reflections”, and rewards the player for completing the initial challenges.

LEVEL MASTER MAP

The global layout of **"Reflections"** is structured into four primary segments, connected through a central hub:

- **Mirror Hall:** The base and central node that bridges all other areas.
- **Estructura (Left):** A stage tailored for Ego's physical moveset.
- **Nimbo (Right):** A stage tailored for Anima's ethereal moveset.
- **Faro (Top):** The final challenge area located above the Mirror Hall.

Note: Due to document formatting, the map is displayed at a reduced scale. A high-resolution version is provided in the following link.



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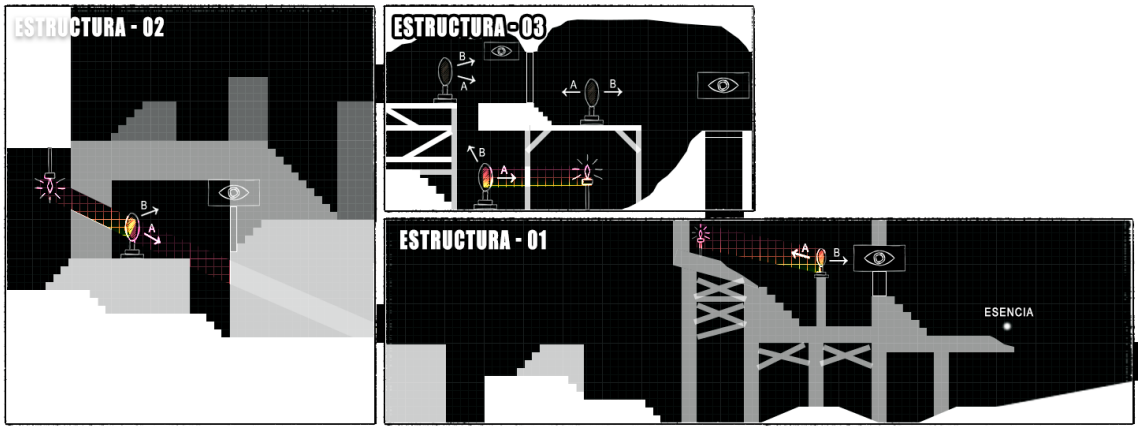
The connections between these areas are represented by black path lines. It is important to highlight that **Estructura** and **Nimbo** function as mirrored versions of one another, maintaining the level's core metaphor of duality.

However, while they are visually and structurally inverted, they are not identical: key interactive elements are substituted or modified to align with the specific gameplay mechanics of either Ego or Anima.

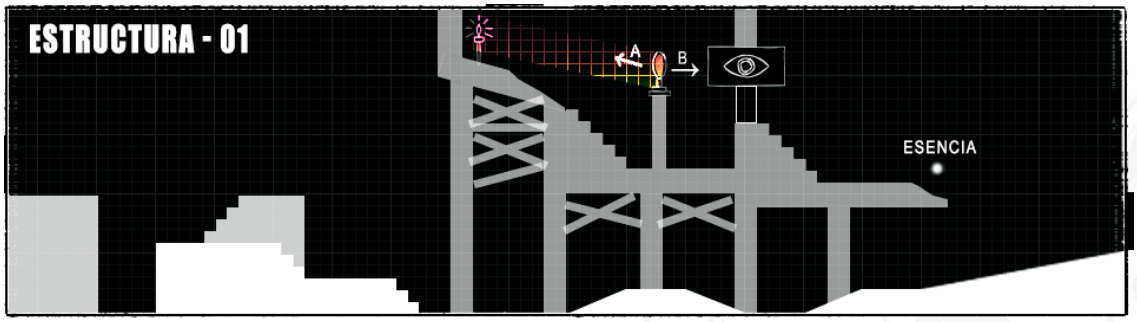
SCENARIO MAPS

This section details the three core scenarios that comprise "Reflections": **Estructura**, **Nimbo**, and **Faro**.

1. Estructura



Estructura is a scenario designed exclusively for **Ego**. It provides a controlled environment for the player to solve introductory logic puzzles and experiment with the Dash mechanic. Also, to ensure a smooth learning curve, Estructura is divided into three independent sections:



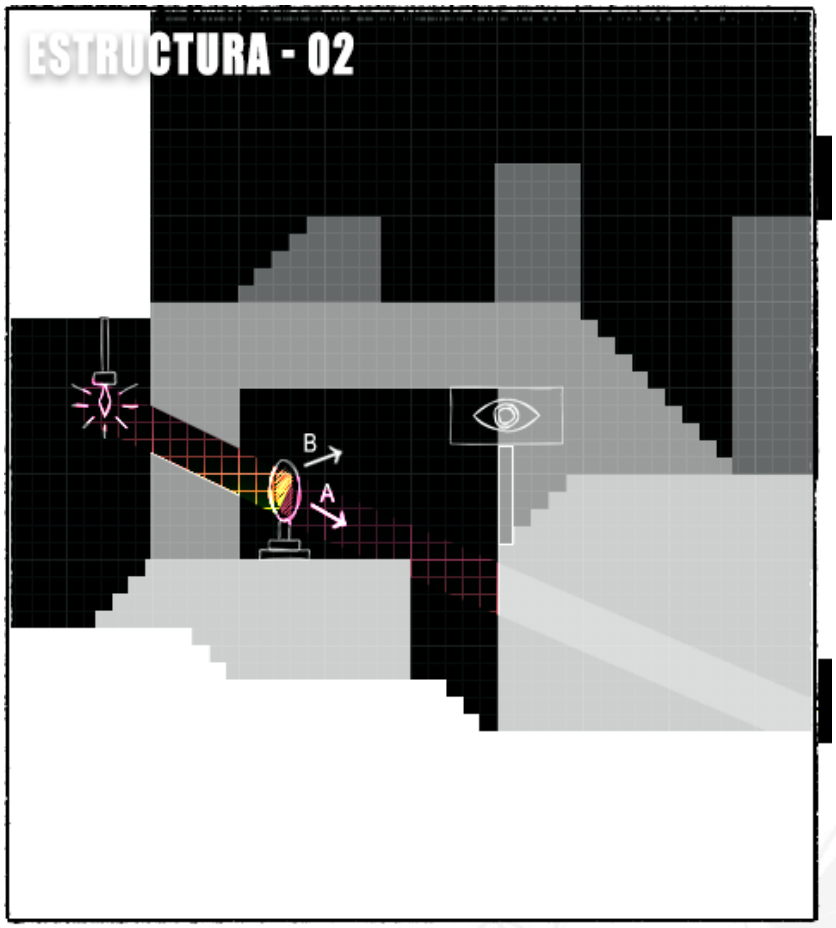
Estructura – 01

The first section of this scenario acts as an introductory space with no complex logic challenges.

- **Navigation:** The player begins at the far-right edge and progresses toward the left.

- **Objective Teasing:** From the start, the primary goal—the "**Esencia**"—is visually established. However, it remains out of immediate reach, forcing the player to explore the environment.

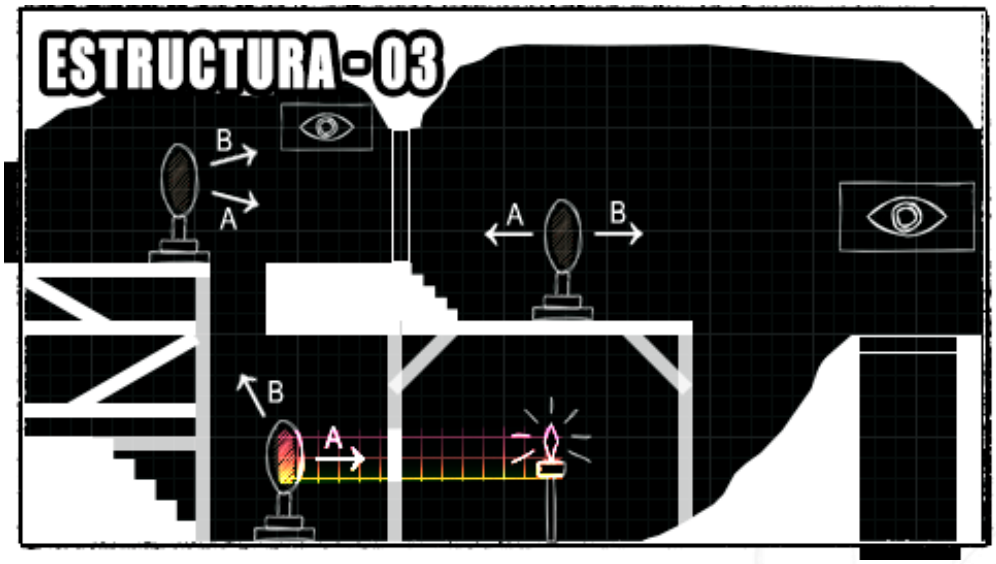
- **Movement Challenge:** The path leads to a gap between a set of stairs and the platform transition to the next section. To clear this gap, the player must execute a Jump combined with a Dash, effectively teaching the player the required distance and timing for Ego's traversal kit.



Estructura – 02

The player enters from the bottom-right corner and exits through the top-right. This section introduces two distinct gameplay layers:

- **Introductory Mirror Puzzle:** This serves as a tutorial to teach the player that Ego's Dash can interact with "Reflective Mirrors."
  - **The Interaction:** A single physical impact toggles the mirror from Angle A (default) to Angle B.
  - **The Outcome:** This redirects the light beam toward the Eye, which acts as a switch to lower or deploy a bridge, allowing the player to proceed.
- **Platforming Challenge:** At the end of the section, the player must chain two Jump-Dash combos to reach the upper exit. This requires precise spatial awareness and timing to manage the character's momentum.



Estructura – 03

The player enters from the top-left corner and faces a complex Sequential Logic Puzzle. This section marks the first time the player must manipulate multiple mirrors to achieve a multi-step objective.

- **Sequential Puzzle:**
  - **Step 1:** The player drops to the ground level to strike the first mirror, aligning the source beam with the second mirror.

- **Step 2:** Striking the second mirror illuminates the first Eye, unlocking the first gate and granting access to the third mirror.

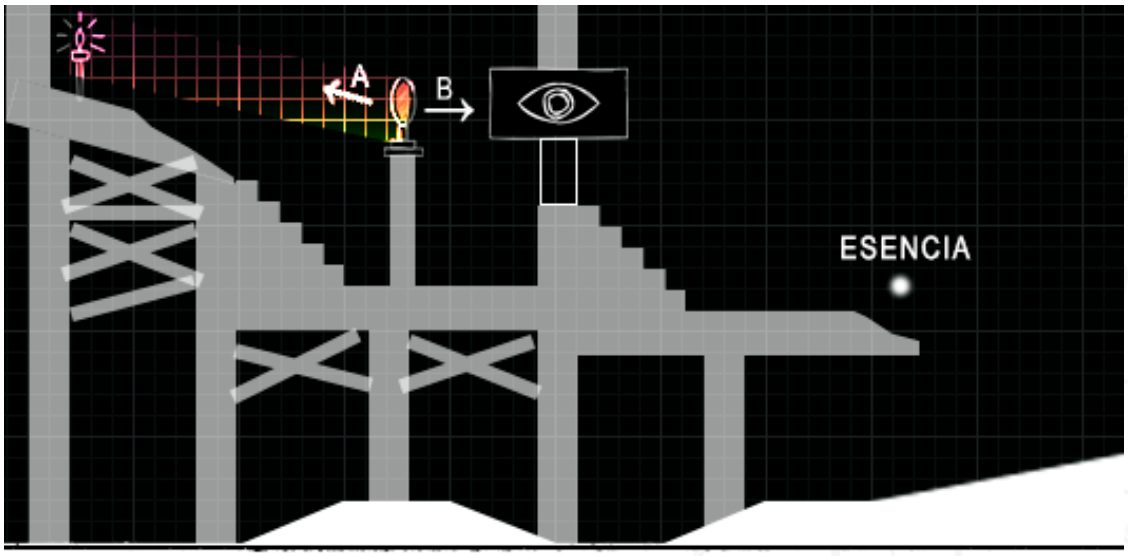
- **Step 3 (Reconfiguration):** The player must strike the second mirror again to return it to its original Angle (A). This reroutes the beam toward the third mirror.

- **Step 4:** Striking the third mirror activates the second Eye, opening a trapdoor for the final descent.

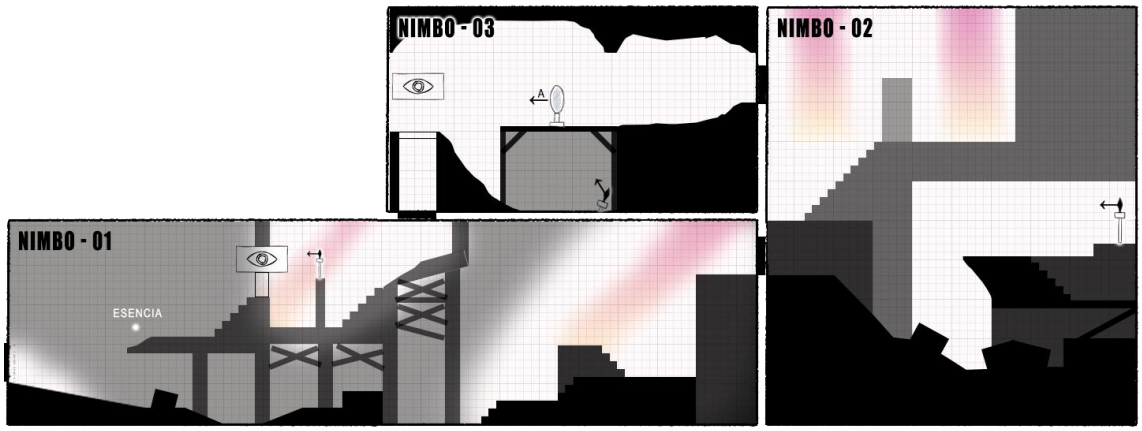
▪ **Return to Estructura – 01:** Falling through the trapdoor returns the player to the upper, previously inaccessible platform of **Estructura–01**.

- **Skill Check:** The player faces a high-precision challenge: a Mid-air Dash-Strike. They must jump and time their Dash to hit a mirror mounted on a narrow pillar while in motion.

- **Reward:** Successful execution redirects the beam to the final Eye, unlocking the chamber containing the first **Esencia**.

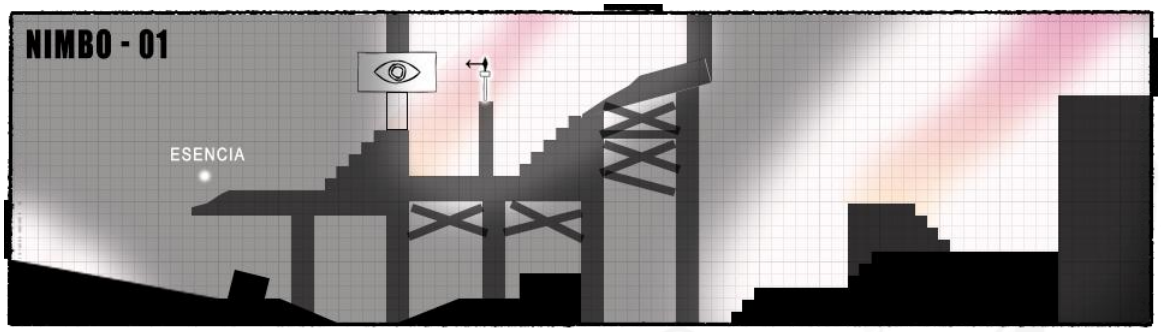


2. Nimbo



Nimbo is a scenario designed exclusively for **Anima**. It serves as an experimental space for the player to master the **Light Form** mechanic through introductory environmental puzzles.

Following the established level structure, Nimbo is divided into three independent sections:



Nimbo – 01

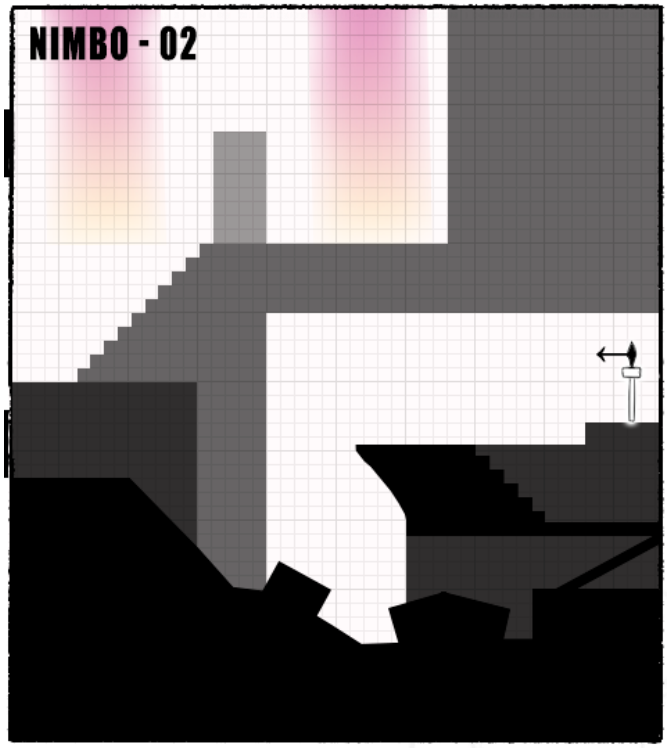
The first section of this scenario focuses on **environmental visibility** and introduces Anima's core traversal mechanic.

- **Navigation:** The player begins at the far-left edge and progresses toward the right.

- **Lighting Mechanic:** A significant portion of this section is shrouded in darkness, represented on the map by dark shadows over the white background. The player is encouraged to adopt Anima's **Light Form** to illuminate the path and reveal the environment.

- **Beam Navigation:** The path leads to a set of stairs and a pedestal where a light beam is focused (represented by a reddish hue on the map).

- **Traversal Check:** While in **Light Form**, Anima can merge with and travel through this beam to reach the upper platform, granting access to the next section.



Nimbo – 02

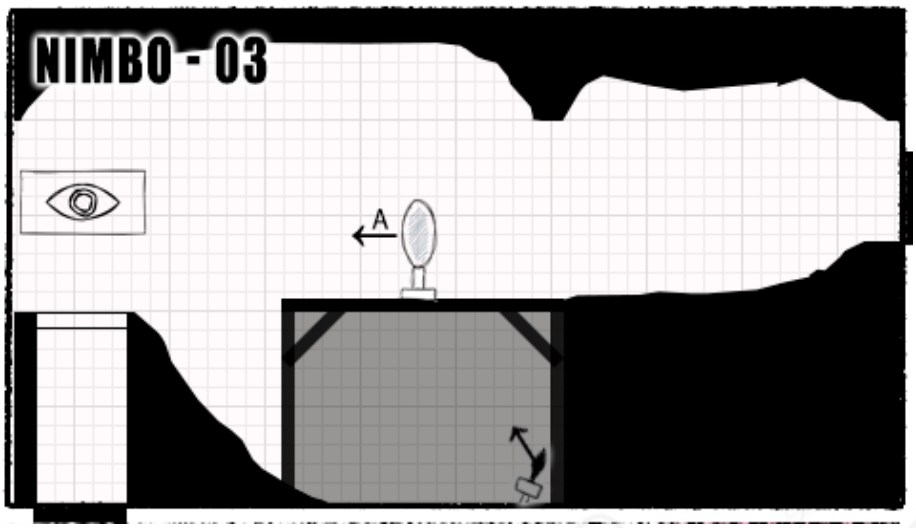
In this section, the player descends a slope and overcomes a basic platforming challenge to reach a **Damaged Source** (represented by a diamond icon on a pedestal, with an arrow indicating the future beam trajectory).

- **Timed Traversal:** While in Light Form, Anima can temporarily jumpstart this source. This generates a **decaying light beam** that serves as a safe pathway. The player must navigate through this beam to reach a distant platform that is inaccessible via standard jumping.

- **Vertical Momentum Challenge:** After ascending a second set of stairs, the player faces a more demanding platforming sequence involving **Descending Beams**:

    - **Phase 1:** The player must reach the furthest descending beam and use it to elevate Anima's Light Form, precisely timing the exit to land on an intermediate platform.

    - **Phase 2:** This process is repeated with a second descending beam to successfully reach the section's exit portal.



Nimbo – 03

This section presents a deceptive challenge featuring a **Reflective Mirror**, a locked trapdoor, and an **Eye**, but with no visible light source in the immediate area.

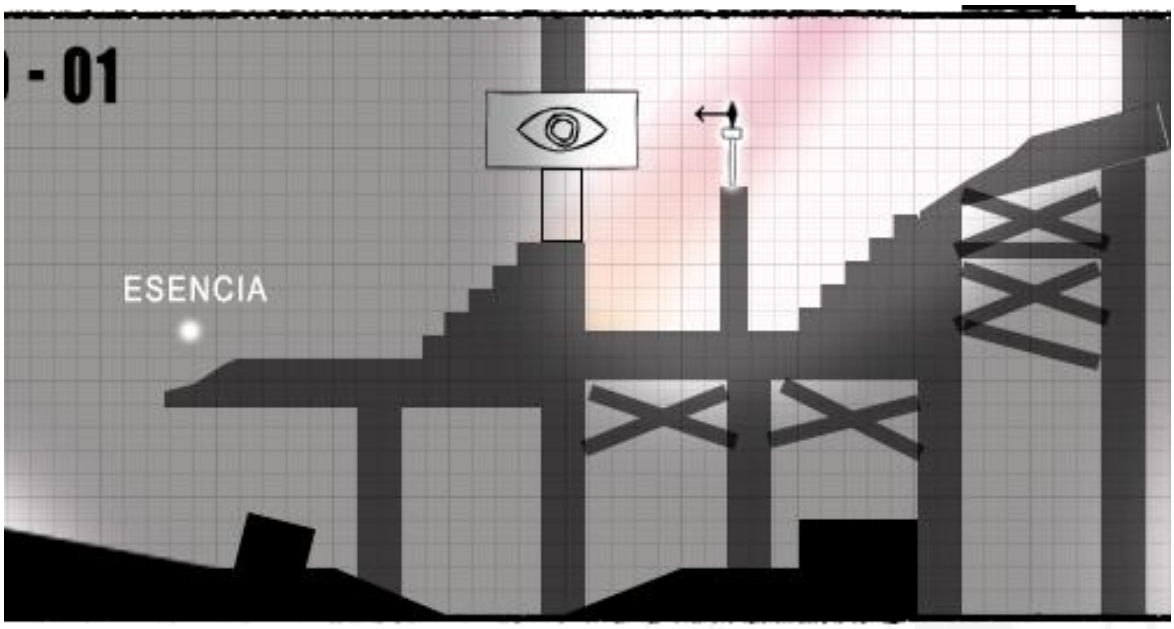
- **Hidden Logic & Discovery:** The player must investigate a darkened area beneath the mirror using Light Form. This reveals a **Hidden Damaged Source**.

- **The Sequence:** Anima must jumpstart this hidden source to project a temporary beam. This beam reflects off the mirror to trigger the Eye, unlocking the trapdoor for the final descent.

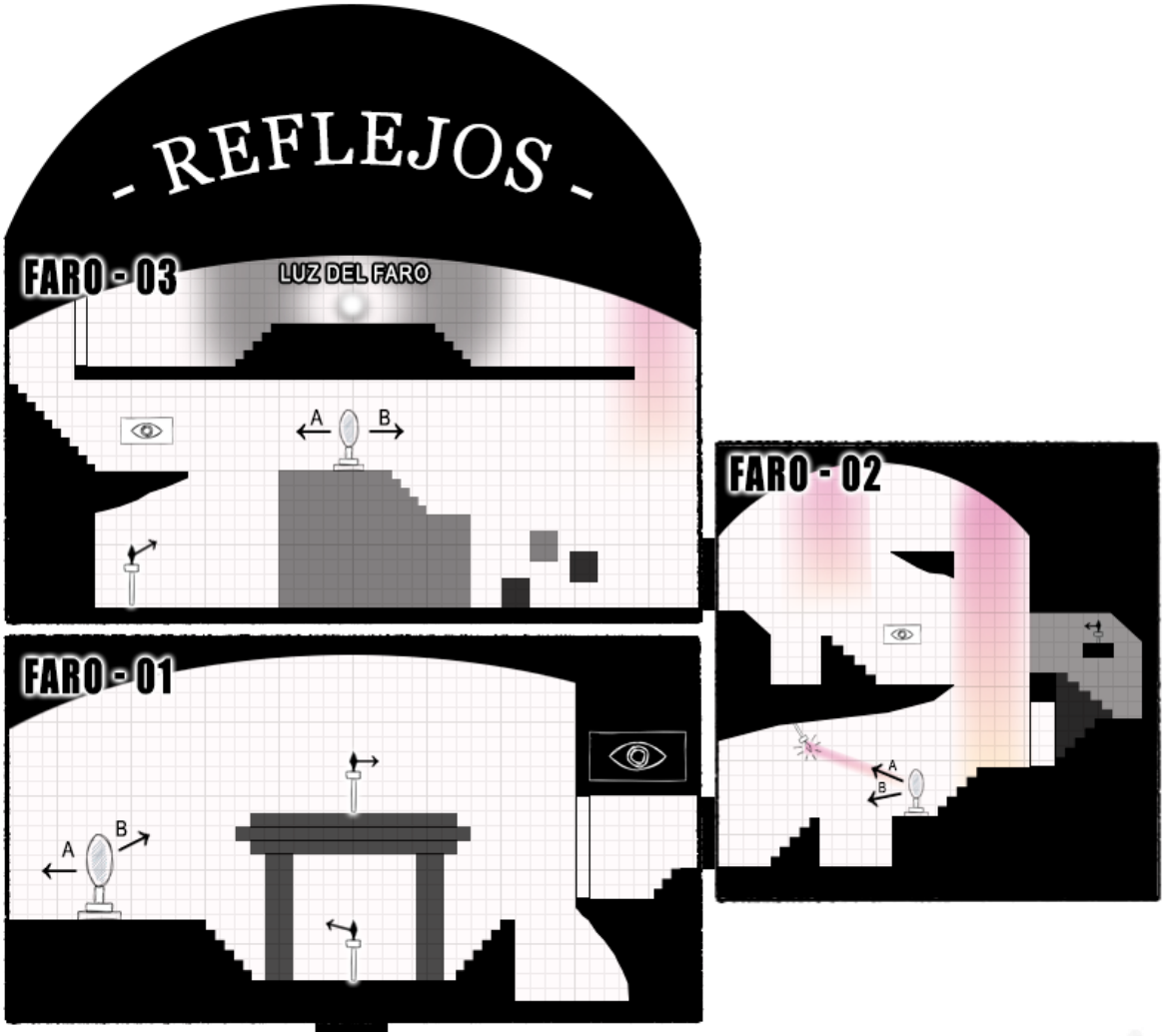
- **Return to Nimbo – 01:** Falling through the trapdoor places the player on a high-altitude structure within **Nimbo – 01** that was previously out of reach.

    - **Advanced Traversal Skill:** To reach the second **Esencia**, the player must execute a **Mid-air Transformation**. This involves jumping into the void and shifting into Light Form while falling to catch a specific light beam.

    - **Final Trigger:** Once inside the beam, Anima must power one last **Damaged Source** to unlock the chamber and claim the **Esencia**.



3. Faro



Faro (which means “lighthouse” in Spanish) is the final stage where the player must master the synergy between **Ego** and **Anima**. Access to this area is only granted once both characters have secured their respective **Esencias**. At this pivotal moment, the central mirror in the **Mirror Hall** shatters, physically reuniting the protagonists and unlocking the **Character Swap** mechanic.

The transition to this stage is facilitated by a central elevator that ascends from the hub directly into the lighthouse’s first section.

Faro – 01

This section introduces the first Cooperative Puzzle, requiring synchronized actions:

- **Ego's Role:** He must strike a mirror to toggle its angle from A to B.
- **Anima's Role:** This redirection allows Anima to reach and ignite a primary torch.
- **The Synergy:** Anima then navigates the resulting light beam to reach a secondary torch. Igniting it triggers an Eye sensor, unlocking the gate for both characters to proceed together.

Faro – 02

The complexity increases by requiring characters to clear paths for one another from different spatial planes:

- **The Gap:** Ego utilizes a Mid-air Dash to cross a chasm, reaching a position where he can strike a mirror to generate a light path for Anima.
- **Discovery:** Anima ascends via this beam and uses her Light Form to reveal a Hidden Damaged Source in a darkened area. Activating it opens a door, allowing Ego to ascend the stairs and regroup.
- **Parallel Traversal:** The section concludes with a dual challenge: Ego performs another precise Mid-air Dash while Anima navigates a series of light beams to reach the exit portal.

Faro – 03

The final section is a symbolic and visually striking ascent at the lighthouse's highest point.

- **The Ascent:** Ego navigates a platforming sequence to reach the upper mirror, while Anima activates a **Damaged Source** in the lower-left quadrant. This triggers an Eye that unlocks the final gate for Ego.

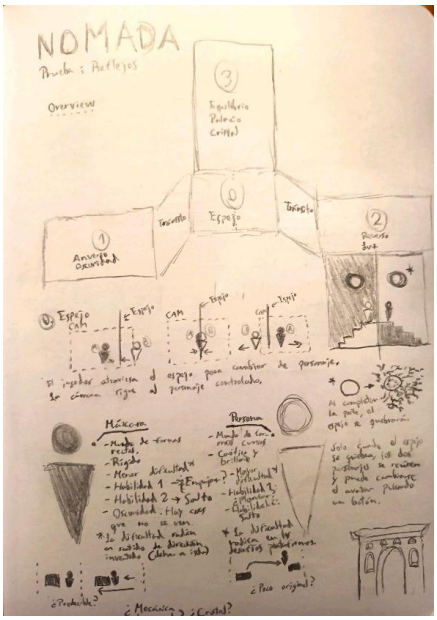
- **The Reunion:** Once at the summit, Ego strikes the final mirror to reverse the beam's direction, creating a path that Anima follows to meet him at the top.

- **Completion:** By reaching the peak together, the characters reclaim the **Luz del Faro**, successfully completing the level.

DESIGN MEMOIR

FROM SEED TO CONCEPT

After a thorough review of the requirements, I identified the core pillars for the project:



- **Genre:** Puzzle-Platformer inspired by GRIS and Neva.
- **Character Swap:** A dual-character system (non-simultaneous) with persistent positioning.
- **Core Kit:** Two abilities per character (including a jump/traversal mechanic).
- **Level Depth:** A signature level mechanic with systemic depth.
- **Structure:** A three-act progression (Solo Ego / Solo Anima / Cooperative Climax).

The brief immediately suggested two foundational themes: **Duality** and **Cooperation**. Drawing from the target references, I decided to treat the level design not just as a technical exercise, but as a narrative vehicle.

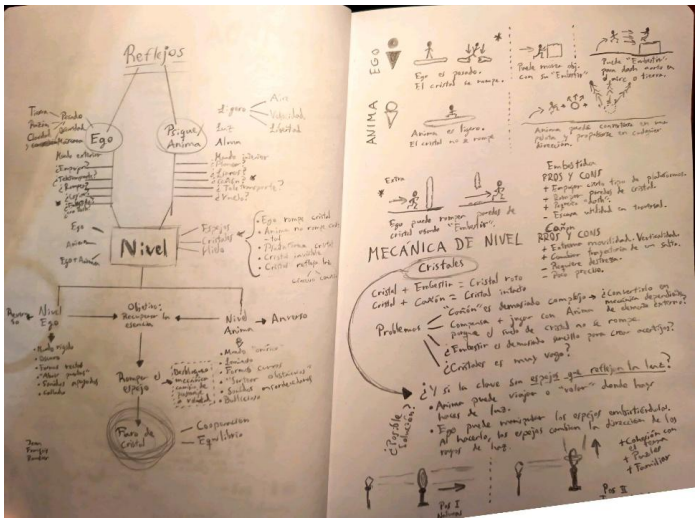
NARRATIVE METAPHOR & DEVELOPMENT

Inspired by the abstract sensitivity of GRIS, I centered the level on a conceptual theme: the "masks" we wear to navigate society.

- **Ego:** Represents the social mask. The external self that interacts with the physical world.

- **Anima:** Represents the authentic, intimate identity. An ethereal essence that defies physical constraints.

This duality dictated the level's architecture. I decided that before unlocking the swap button, the player must transition between worlds through a **physical mirror**. To reinforce this, the first two scenarios were designed as **structurally identical but inverted maps**, embodying the mirror metaphor.



MECHANICS & RATIONALIZATION

I opted for simplicity and originality over common tropes like double-jumping.

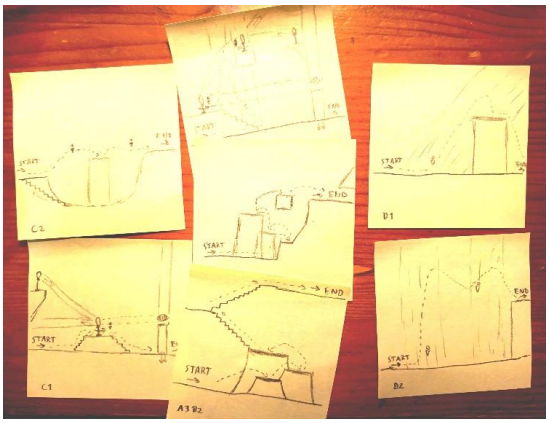
- **Ego (Physicality):** Uses Dash to manipulate the environment.

- **Anima (Ethereal):** Uses Light to flow through the stage, breaking standard physical rules.

- **Standardization:** Both characters share the same jump metrics. This ensures mechanical consistency and prevents player frustration in a standalone trial.

LEVEL MECHANIC: REFLECTIVE MIRRORS

The greatest challenge was defining the signature mechanic. After iterating on several ideas, I chose Reflective Mirrors. They serve as a direct extension of the narrative metaphor.



Before finalizing the design, I conducted **paper prototyping** to ensure that the interaction between Dash, Light, and Mirrors could generate a varied and scalable puzzle logic.

PRODUCTION & REFLECTION

Despite technical setbacks (including a system crash and connectivity issues) I managed to deliver the project within the deadline. Looking back with a "Post-Mortem" lens, if granted more time, I would focus on:

- **Visual Clarity:** Enhancing the legibility of the Level Maps in Exercise 3 to reduce reliance on text descriptions.
- **Information Architecture:** Streamlining the documentation in Exercise 1 to eliminate redundancies.

Ultimately, I am satisfied with the result. I believe “Reflections” stands as a testament to narrative-driven level design, where every jump and every beam of light serves a deeper metaphorical purpose.

Ricardo Caballero Pascual